population. Two decades after Nixon and Mao first established ties between their two countries, it seemed as though China's historical development indeed would make it an increasingly important economic partner of the United States. Bill Clinton's shepherding of China into the World Trade Organization at the end of his administration served as an official endorsement of the hopes placed on Beijing and its normalization into the world order.

Few, however, could have foreseen just how quickly China would develop and how powerful a role it would play in the global economy, far eclipsing even Japan at its height. From a bit player, Chinese manufacturing dominated dozens of consumer sectors by the 2000s, and the country overtook Japan to become the world's second-largest economy by 2011. From steel to consumer electronics, and from textiles to solar panels Chinese manufacturers took over entire industries. The flag followed trade, so to speak, and just as had happened with Japan several decades previously, American policy makers, analysts, and pundits soon began to tout China as the next great world power. It seemed natural, to Americans at least, that the world's most populous nation would also become one of its leading political powers. With that power, Americans assumed, Beijing (as now spelled, in the phonetic system preferred by the Chinese government) would accept global responsibility, helping to support the system instituted by the Western victors after World War II. As such, Washington and Beijing no longer would simply be engaged in a transactional relationship; the two instead would be the pillars of a post–Cold War order, a "G-2" that could shape global economic, political, and strategic issues.

The George W. Bush administration created several mechanisms in conjunction with the Chinese to elevate top-level official exchanges that would reflect Beijing's new prominence. The Senior Dialogue began in the summer of 2005, followed by the Strategic Economic Dialogue in December 2006. The goal, as expressed in a speech by then deputy secretary of state Robert Zoellick, who also represented the United States at the Senior Dialogue, was to make China a "responsible stakeholder" in the international system.[9] The same desire was shared